



Photographs by GIREESH GV

sports MOTOR RACING

NK'S NEW RACE

Narain Karthikeyan, India's first Formula 1 driver, takes on a different role, at the head of his own racing team that is a serious contender in the ongoing national racing championships

■ By Sharda Ugra

Enough, leave them alone..." Narain Karthikeyan is stomping around the pit in front of a banner with his face on it. He is climbing over tools and across equipment, through a swarm of mechanics dressed in the electric green and black of Speed NK Racing.

Qualifying hasn't gone well, one gear box seems possessed by an evil spirit, a clutch is throwing a tantrum, the team drivers are being instructed and interrogated, but Karthikeyan has called a time out. "Let them be. Now they just need to go out and drive."

It is the second round of the 10th JK Tyre National Racing Championships. Speed NK Racing, Karthikeyan's outfit, lead in the standings amongst 14 cars at the Kari Motor Speedway outside Coimbatore, in a place signposted by the local panchayat as the "classical, divine Tamil township of Chettipalayam."

This is NK Racing's second year in the championships, where they field two cars in the Formula Rolon Chevrolet class, the highest of the three classes involved. The other two are the Formula LGB Swift and the Formula LGB Hyundai. NK Racing's drivers are Chennai teenagers Aditya Patel, 18,

and Saran Vikram, 17, one the son of a former racer and the other of a garage mechanic. Two other drivers, Saahil Shelar from Mumbai and Ajay Kini from Chennai are part of the Amaron NK Racing Academy, and have been placed with the Chennai-based WSRF team for the Rolons.

Kamlesh Patel, father of Aditya with three decades of racing behind him, says the two NK Racing drivers have a "two in a billion opportunity" to work with a driver of Karthikeyan's experience.

India's first Formula 1 driver is putting in the mandatory night shifts with race engineer and cousin Sanjay Balu